

Hanukkah — Festival of Lights

Judaism • Holiday Collage

WHAT IT IS & WHY IT MATTERS

Hanukkah is an eight-day Jewish festival that celebrates the rededication of the Second Temple in Jerusalem after it was recaptured from the Seleucid Greeks. It is a minor holiday in Jewish law, but it carries major meaning as a story of religious freedom and Jewish survival against forced assimilation. Each night a candle is added to the menorah, so the light grows instead of fading. For Judaism as a whole, Hanukkah affirms that a small, faithful community can preserve its identity and worship even under pressure.

WHEN IT OCCURS

Hanukkah begins on the 25th of Kislev and lasts eight days, ending on the 2nd or 3rd of Tevet. Kislev is the ninth month of the Jewish civil calendar and falls in winter. Because the Jewish calendar is lunisolar, the date shifts on the modern Gregorian calendar each year. On our calendar Hanukkah normally falls in late November through December.

SCRIPTURAL & HISTORICAL ROOTS

In 168 BCE the Seleucid king Antiochus IV outlawed Jewish practice and defiled the Temple by setting up pagan worship inside it. A priestly family, the Maccabees, led by Mattathias and then his son Judah, revolted and recaptured Jerusalem in 164 BCE. The events are recorded in 1 and 2 Maccabees rather than in the Hebrew Bible itself. Rabbinic tradition (Talmud, Shabbat 21b) adds the miracle of the oil: one day's worth of undefiled Temple oil burned for eight days until new oil could be prepared, which is why the holiday lasts eight nights.

[Insert image]

Hanukkiah (nine-branched menorah): eight lights for the eight nights plus the shamash, the helper candle used to light the others.

[Insert image]

Dreidel: a four-sided top marked nun, gimel, hey, shin — "a great miracle happened there" — used in a traditional Hanukkah game.

[Insert image]

Latkes and sufganiyot: potato pancakes and jelly doughnuts fried in oil, eaten to recall the miracle of the Temple oil.

[Insert image]

Olive oil and the Temple: pure oil was pressed for the Temple lamp, the detail at the center of the Hanukkah story.

Purim — Feast of Lots

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Purim celebrates the rescue of the Jews of the Persian Empire from a plot to destroy them. It is a joyful holiday marked by public reading of the Scroll of Esther, costumes, gifts of food, charity to the poor, and a festive meal. Its importance in Judaism is that it remembers survival in the diaspora, where Jews were a vulnerable minority under a foreign king. God is never named in the Book of Esther, so the holiday is also read as a lesson about hidden providence and human courage.

WHEN IT OCCURS

Purim falls on the 14th of Adar, the twelfth month of the Jewish religious calendar. In leap years, when a second Adar is added, it is observed in Adar II. Walled cities such as Jerusalem observe Shushan Purim on the 15th of Adar. On the modern calendar Purim lands in late February or March.

SCRIPTURAL & HISTORICAL ROOTS

The story comes from the biblical Book of Esther, set in Persia under King Ahasuerus. Haman, the king's chief minister, was insulted when the Jew Mordecai refused to bow to him, so he cast lots (purim) to choose a date to kill all the Jews of the empire. Esther, Mordecai's cousin and the queen, hid her Jewish identity until she risked her life to approach the king and expose Haman's plan. The decree was reversed, Haman was executed on the gallows he had built for Mordecai, and Mordecai and Esther established the annual observance (Esther 9:20–28).

[Insert image]

Megillat Esther: the handwritten Scroll of Esther, read aloud in synagogue on Purim eve and again the next morning.

[Insert image]

Gragger (noisemaker): spun to blot out Haman's name every time it is read during the Megillah.

[Insert image]

Hamantaschen: three-cornered filled pastries named for Haman, said to resemble his hat or his ears.

[Insert image]

Mishloach manot: baskets of food given to friends, one of the four commanded observances of Purim along with charity to the poor.